

It's 2026, and the tech world feels like it's doing donuts in a time machine. On one side, we're strapping on space-age gadgets – foldable phones, AI assistants that don't even need screens, and smart glasses that look suspiciously like... normal glasses. On the other, some old favourites are staging a comeback (hello again, microSD cards), and everyone's suddenly fussing about boring-but-important stuff like whether your smart home gadgets will stay smart long enough to justify their price.

In India, where jugaad lives happily beside bleeding-edge, these shifts land in very specific ways: we love value, we hate paying more for less, we adopt fast when it's genuinely useful, and we complain loudly when brands remove features we actually use. So here's a casual tour of 2026's biggest tech trends – and what they mean for the rest of us.

Less RAM, price rise, and microSD revival

For years, the story was simple: every new phone or laptop arrived with more RAM than the last, and we all pretended that meant we'd become more productive humans. In 2026, that neat upgrade ladder is wobbling. Some new devices are sticking to lower RAM tiers, even as prices creep up.

What's behind the weirdness? A global memory squeeze, partly driven by the ever-expanding appetite for AI servers and data centres. When the big money is in feeding GPUs, the "everyday device" memory pool doesn't always get first dibs – and that shows up when looking at the bill of materials.

The funniest part is how the industry is responding: by bringing back a feature it spent years trying to kill. The microSD slot – which many brands removed in the name of sleekness (and, let's be honest, upselling storage tiers) – is



suddenly fashionable again. If internal storage is expensive, let people expand it cheaply themselves. It's the most practical "innovation" of the year: re-inventing a feature your aunt has been asking for since 2018.

The timing is also right because newer, faster microSD standards reduce the old "expandable storage is slow" argument. If phone makers actually commit to supporting modern, high-speed cards, a microSD slot stops being a compromise and becomes a consumer-friendly pressure valve. And for India, where people keep phones longer and hoard photos, videos, and WhatsApp forwards like family heirlooms, this is a genuinely useful comeback.

Foldables go mainstream (for real this time)

Foldable phones have lived in the "cool, but... why?" zone for years: exciting demos, premium pricing, and just enough durability anxiety to make sane people step back. In 2026, the category finally looks ready to graduate.

Why now? Iteration. Hinges have improved. Creases are less distracting. Software is more fold-aware. Competition has grown. The format is also easier to explain to non-geeks: it's a phone when closed, a bigger screen when open. That's it. No metaphors needed.

The other ingredient is the one that always changes markets: major eco-

systems treating foldables as "normal." Once platforms and app developers stop treating foldables like a niche oddity, everything around them gets smoother – accessories, app layouts, retail push, service and support. For consumers, that means fewer compromises and more confidence. For India, it means foldables start shifting from "luxury flex" to "aspirational upgrade," especially as older models trickle down in price.

Are foldables perfect? No. They're still pricier than similar slab phones, and you'll still be more careful with



them than with a regular glass-sandwich device. But 2026 looks like the year foldables stop being a novelty and start being a real category choice.

Gaming grows up, as esports breaks from RMG

India's online gaming story in the early 2020s got tangled with real-money gaming so often that many people assumed "gaming" basically meant "apps that want your wallet." That confusion has been toxic for competitive gaming and for how parents, brands, and regulators view the whole space.

Now the conversation is shifting. As eSports gets formally treated as a legitimate competitive category, it's